

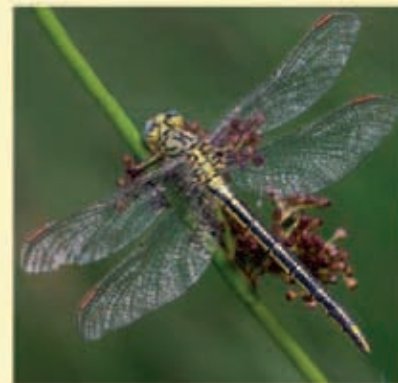
Insects

With more than 800,000 species identified so far, insects make up the biggest group of arthropods. Adult insects have six legs and most have two pairs of wings. When insects grow up, they change in shape, undergoing partial or complete metamorphosis.

Dragonflies

Adult dragonflies catch insects in midair. Some patrol in search of food, while others dart from a perch. Dragonflies spend the first part of their lives in freshwater, as predatory nymphs. These have hinged mouthparts that can shoot forward, grabbing their prey.

Dragonflies' transparent wings stay spread at rest, not folded like those of most other insects.



Partial transformers

Insects in this group undergo a slight change in shape, or partial metamorphosis. Their young, known as nymphs, look similar to their parents, although they have small wing buds instead of working wings. Each time they molt, their wing buds get larger. After the final molt, the nymph becomes an adult. Nymphs and adults often live in the same surroundings and eat the same kinds of food.



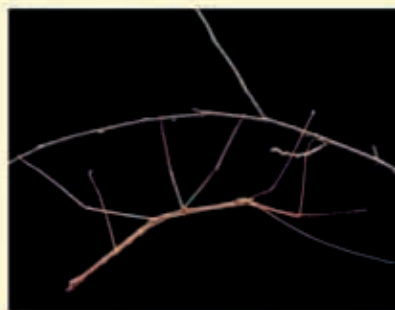
Grasshoppers typically have tough, leathery forewings. Their hind wings are large, but they usually escape predators by jumping with powerful hind legs.



Katydids have threadlike antennae that are often longer than their bodies.



Earwigs' abdomens are tipped by curved pincers. Their hind wings fold beneath stubby forewings.



Stick insects are camouflaged in undergrowth by their extraordinary twiglike bodies.



Cockroaches sense vibration and flee fast from danger, squeezing their flat bodies into crevices.

Termites often form huge colonies that build elaborate nests. Some chew on wood, which they digest with the help of microorganisms in the gut. Others are important grazers in grasslands.



Praying mantises hunt insects, catching them with a swift strike of their barbed forelegs.



Like many true bugs, cicadas drink plant sap with piercing mouthparts. Adult males sing loudly.



Thorn bugs, or treehoppers, suck sap secretly, disguised as one of the plant's thorns.



Water bugs grip prey with their forelegs while sucking it dry with their syringelike mouths.